India–Fiji: Building Bridges, Shaping Futures

Foreword

Fiji occupies a strategically important position in the South Pacific, serving as one of the region's most connected economies and an important commercial, tourism, logistics and services hub for the wider Pacific Island region. With a population of under one million people, a diversified economy anchored in tourism, agriculture, sugar, fisheries, services and emerging digital activities, and strong connectivity with neighbouring Pacific markets, Fiji offers India a distinctive platform for long-term economic engagement. At the same time, its relatively small domestic market, geographic distance from India, high transportation and logistics costs, exposure to cyclones and other climate-related risks, and limited production scale create practical constraints that must be carefully considered when assessing commercial opportunities.

India and Fiji share a relationship rooted in longstanding historical, cultural and people-to-people connections, supported by diplomatic relations established in 1970 and reinforced through regular political engagement, development cooperation, capacity-building programmes and institutional exchanges. The presence of a substantial Indian-origin community in Fiji provides an additional foundation for commercial and social linkages between the two countries. Bilateral economic engagement has scope to expand beyond traditional areas into pharmaceuticals, healthcare, automobiles and machinery, renewable energy, sugar-sector modernisation, agriculture, fisheries, tourism, education, digital services and technology. India's competitive strengths in pharmaceuticals, engineering, information technology, renewable-energy solutions, agricultural technologies and affordable consumer products complement Fiji's development priorities and its role as a gateway to wider Pacific markets.



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Introduction

Fiji is a strategically located island nation in the South Pacific Ocean, known for its role as a regional hub for trade, tourism and diplomacy in Oceania. India and Fiji share historical, cultural and economic ties, mainly due to the large Indian-origin population in Fiji.

Fiji has a diplomatic mission/representation in New Delhi, and the relationship between both countries continues to strengthen through trade, development cooperation and people-to- people linkages

Basic Facts

Fiji is a republic with a parliamentary democracy and a member of the United Nations, Commonwealth of Nations and Pacific Islands Forum. It consists of over 300 islands, of which around 110 are inhabited. The country plays a leadership role among Pacific island nations due to its political stability, infrastructure and regional connectivity.

GDP (Gross Domestic Product) & Currency:

Fiji's nominal GDP is estimated at around US$ 5 billion. The economy is service-driven, mainly supported by tourism, trade, agriculture and remittances. Despite its small size, Fiji functions as a key economic and financial center for the Pacific island region. The official currency of Fiji is the Fijian Dollar (FJD). It is regulated by the Reserve Bank of Fiji and is stable relative to other Pacific island currencies.

Population

Fiji has a population of approximately 9.3–9.4 lakh (0.93 million) people. A significant percentage of Fiji's population is of Indian origin, descended from Indian labourers brought during the British colonial period. This Indo-Fijian community strongly influences the cultural, economic and political landscape of the country.



Cultural and Heritage:
Fiji has a vibrant cultural heritage shaped by indigenous iTaukei traditions and Indian influences. Traditional customs, communal living, music, dance, and ceremonies like yaqona (kava) rituals are central to Fijian life, reflecting a blend of Pacific and multicultural identities.

Trade with India (Bilateral Trade – in Billions)

India–Fiji bilateral trade is modest but steady and is estimated at around US$ 0.09–0.12 billion annually. India exports form the larger share, while imports from Fiji remain limited. Although the trade volume is small due to Fiji's limited market size, there is increasing scope for expansion in pharmaceuticals, food products, renewable energy and healthcare.



Import & Export from India

India exports a wide range of products to Fiji, including pharmaceuticals, rice, engineering goods, automobiles and spare parts, chemicals, textiles, electrical equipment and consumer goods. From Fiji, India imports limited quantities of agricultural products, marine products and raw materials. Indian pharmaceutical products, in particular, have a strong presence in Fiji due to affordability and quality.

Culture & Economic Ties with India

India–Fiji relations are deeply rooted in shared history, culture and diaspora connections. Nearly 38–40% of Fiji's population is of Indian origin, making it one of the strongest cultural bridges between India and the Pacific region. Indian festivals, food, language and traditions are widely practiced in Fiji. India actively supports Fiji through development assistance, healthcare projects, education programmes, renewable energy, and capacity building under initiatives like ITEC and ICCR scholarships. Bilateral cooperation also covers climate change, disaster management, digital public infrastructure and skill development.

Strategic Importance & Key Observations

Fiji is strategically important for India as a gateway to the Pacific Island region. It offers strong potential for Indian businesses in pharmaceuticals, renewable energy, education, ICT, healthcare infrastructure, agro-processing and tourism services. For Fiji, India is a reliable development partner and a major source of affordable medicines, technology and capacity-building support. With growing diplomatic engagement and economic cooperation, the India–Fiji partnership is expected to expand steadily in the coming years.

1. Fiji: Economic Profile and Business Environment

1.1 Country overview

Fiji is an archipelago of more than three hundred islands in the South Pacific, with a population of just under a million, most living on the two main islands of Viti Levu and Vanua Levu. The capital, Suva, hosts regional organisations and a major regional university, while Nadi on the western side hosts the international airport and the tourism industry. Fiji is classified as an upper-middle-income economy.

1.2 Structure of the economy

- **Tourism:** the largest earner of foreign exchange and a major employer, drawing visitors mainly from Australia, New Zealand, the United States and the region.
- **Sugar and agriculture:** sugar cane, ginger, turmeric, kava, root crops, coconut and tropical fruit.
- **Fisheries and forestry:** tuna and other marine products, timber, and mahogany and pine plantations.
- **Manufacturing:** garments, bottled water, food processing, and building materials.
- **Services:** transport, aviation, education, business services and finance.
- **Remittances:** significant inflows from the diaspora and from workers overseas.

1.3 Regional role

Fiji functions as the commercial, transport and diplomatic hub of the South Pacific. Fiji Airways connects the islands with Oceania, Asia and North America. The country hosts the headquarters of several regional organisations and the main campus of a regional university. Its ports in Suva and Lautoka serve as transhipment points for neighbouring island countries.

1.4 Trade arrangements

Fiji participates in regional and international trade arrangements, including island-level trade agreements, a broader economic partnership with Australia and New Zealand, and arrangements with the European Union. It maintains relations with major partners in the Asia-Pacific. Preferential access for Fijian goods to some markets and the small scale of the domestic market shape trade policy.

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